

Order Returns - Agent Knowledge Base

How to determine return eligibility, handle restricted items, distinguish remorse returns from fulfillment errors, and process exceptions.

Prototype disclaimer

Synthetic sample policy for prototyping and RAG evaluation. This document is fictional operational guidance, not a statement of any real company's policy. Adapt, validate, and approve it before production use.

Retrieval metadata

Applies to: customer support agents, ticket triage agents, and automated support agents

Recommended ticket tags: return_request, return_window, final_sale, wrong_item, exchange

Policy status: synthetic / test corpus

Policy summary

Most unused, resalable items may be returned within 30 calendar days of confirmed delivery. Some categories are final sale or restricted for hygiene, safety, personalization, or regulatory reasons. The returns workflow should verify item eligibility before promising a label or refund.

Default eligibility

Return request within 30 days + item not final sale + item not materially used or altered = generally eligible. Damage, defect, or wrong-item cases should follow their specialized policy rather than a standard remorse return.

Decision rules

Situation	Agent action	Escalate when
Customer changed mind within 30 days	Confirm item eligibility and issue return instructions. Deduct return shipping only if the storefront policy for that order says so.	Item is restricted, customized, or marked final sale.
Customer requests return after 30 days	Do not promise standard return. Check approved exception criteria.	Exception request involves documented carrier delay, hospitalization, or support error.
Item opened but not materially used	Eligibility depends on category; packaging alone is not an automatic denial.	Hygiene/safety category or item cannot be resold.
Wrong item received	Treat as fulfillment error, not remorse return. Provide prepaid return if needed and replacement/refund option.	High-value mismatch or repeated account pattern.
Customer wants exchange	If direct exchange is unsupported, process return and advise customer to place a new order.	Price-protection or inventory exception is requested.

Restricted categories - synthetic examples

Final sale gift cards, personalized goods, opened perishable goods, and hygiene-sealed products after the seal is broken are normally non-returnable unless defective, damaged, or incorrectly supplied.

Return condition guidance

- Normal inspection of the item is acceptable when compatible with the product category.
- Missing original outer shipping box alone is not a reason to reject a return.
- Material wear, modification, contamination, or missing core components can reduce or eliminate eligibility.

Suggested ticket fields

issue_type=return; order_id; item_sku; delivery_date; request_date; days_since_delivery; return_reason; condition; restricted_category=yes|no; label_issued=yes|no; exception_requested=yes|no

Frequently asked questions

Q: How many days do I have to return an item?

A: The default return window is 30 calendar days from confirmed delivery, subject to item-specific restrictions.

Q: Can I return an opened item?

A: Possibly. Opening packaging does not always make an item ineligible, but hygiene, safety, consumable, and final-sale restrictions still apply.

Q: Who pays return shipping?

A: Follow the policy attached to that order. For wrong, damaged, or defective items, Northstar Commerce generally provides a prepaid return method when a return is required.

Q: Can I exchange for another size or color?

A: If direct exchanges are not supported in the order system, process an eligible return and advise the customer to place a new order.

Q: My return is outside 30 days. Can you make an exception?

A: Do not promise one. Check approved exception criteria and escalate with the reason and evidence.

Q: I received the wrong item. Do I use the standard return flow?

A: No. Classify it as fulfillment error so the customer is not treated as responsible for the return.

Agent response principle

State what is known, distinguish it from what is estimated, give the customer the next concrete step, and never promise an outcome outside the rules in this knowledge base.